

The Noble Sūtra Called 'The Auspicious Night'

Ārya Bhadrarātrī Nāma Sūtra · Toh 617 · Derge Kangyur

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Toh 617 in the Kangyur is a Buddhist sūtra known in Sanskrit as the Ārya Bhadrarātrī Nāma Sūtra and in Tibetan as the Phakpa Tsenmo Zangpo Zhéjawé Do, meaning "The Noble Sūtra Called the Auspicious Night." It is a relatively brief canonical discourse belonging to the sūtra class of texts, in which the Buddha's teaching on the Auspicious Night is framed by an encounter between a monk seated by the Tapodā river at Rājagṛha and a radiant deity who appears in the deep of the night to question him about the sūtra. The text thus centers on the importance of knowing, reciting, and understanding this particular teaching, using the dramatic nighttime dialogue as a vehicle for conveying the sūtra's content and merit. It was translated into Tibetan and definitively edited by the great translator Yeshé Dé.

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In the language of India: Ārya Bhadrarātrī Nāma Sūtra. In the Tibetan language: the noble sūtra called "The Auspicious Night."

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling at Rājagṛha, in the Bamboo Grove of Kalandaka, in the grove of Jīvaka. At that time a monk was sitting on the bank of the Tapodā river at Rājagṛha.

Then a god of supreme and radiant form appeared in the deep of the night, went to where the monk was, and illuminated the entire bank of the Tapodā river with a great spreading light. He spoke to that monk, saying: "Monk, do you know the Sūtra of the Auspicious Night?"

The monk replied: "God, I have not sought out the Sūtra of the Auspicious Night. God, do you know or not know the Sūtra of the Auspicious Night?"

The god said: "Monk, I too do not know the Sūtra of the Auspicious Night."

"God, then who is there who does know the Sūtra of the Auspicious Night in the way you are seeking?"

The god said: "Here in Rājagṛha, in the Bamboo Grove of Kalandaka, the Blessed One is dwelling. Go into the presence of the Blessed One and ask him.

Whatever the Blessed One teaches you, receive it just as he teaches it and apply yourself diligently." Having said this, the god vanished right there and then.

Then the monk, rising at dawn, went to where the Blessed One was, and having arrived, bowed his head at the Blessed One's feet and sat down to one side. Seated to one side, the monk addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"Venerable One, last night, when the dark of night had grown deep, a god of supreme and radiant form came to where I was. He illuminated the entire bank of the Tapodā river with a vast and spreading light, and spoke to me as follows: 'Monk, do you know the Sūtra of the Auspicious Night?' I replied to him: 'God, I have not sought out the Sūtra of the Auspicious Night. God, do you know or not know the Sūtra of the Auspicious Night?' He said to me: 'Monk, I too do not know the Sūtra of the Auspicious Night.' Then he said: 'Then who is there who does know the Sūtra of the Auspicious Night in the way you are seeking?' And he said to me: 'The Blessed One is dwelling here in Rājagṛha, in the Bamboo Grove of Kalandaka. Go into his presence and ask him. Whatever the Blessed One teaches you, receive it just as he teaches it and apply yourself diligently.' Having said this, the god vanished right there and then. Venerable One, Blessed One, it is for this reason that I make this full request of you."

The Blessed One declared: "Monk, do you know who that god was?" The monk replied: "Venerable One, I did not recognize that god." The Blessed One declared: "Son of the gods, that was Tsandana, the leader of the thirty-three gods."

The monk said: "Venerable One, I too wish to hear the Sūtra of the Auspicious Night."

The Blessed One declared: "Monk, therefore listen well and attentively, and hold it in your mind. I shall explain it to you."

"Monk, if a monk possesses three qualities, he is said to dwell in the Sūtra of the Auspicious Night. What are those three? They are as follows: not running after the past with longing, not placing hope in the future, and remaining ungrasped by the phenomena of the present moment. If one possesses these three qualities, a monk is said to dwell in the Sūtra of the Auspicious Night."

The Blessed One having declared this, the Sugata having spoken thus, the Teacher then spoke further in these words:

One does not chase after what has passed.
One places no hope in what has not yet come.
Whatever was past has already ceased,
and what has not come has not yet arrived.

The phenomena arising in the present moment,
each and every one, one beholds with clarity,
ungrasped by conceptual thought.
A wise one knows this inwardly and deeply.

Who knows whether one will die tomorrow?
Therefore, let one exert oneself this very day.
With the great host of the Lord of Death
there is no bargaining, no making it one's own.

May all sentient beings and all living creatures,
all elemental spirits and all beings whatsoever,
come to accomplish happiness and happiness alone,
may all be without affliction.

May all behold what is good,
and may none come to evil.
Abiding thus, with diligent effort,
with no slackness by day or by night,
this is why the Sage ever taught
this sūtra of the Auspicious Night.

Then, in order to protect all sentient beings, the Blessed One, having taught this sūtra of the Auspicious Night, spoke these root mantras of the spirit-soaring secret formulas:

Tadyathā. Vinī viraṇī. Paṇī pūraṇī. Buddhāmarṭe. Maṇīnī. Ni ṇi ṇi ṇi. Ṭi ṭi ṭi ṭi.
Paraṭī. Gaurī. Gāndhārī. Caṇḍālī. Mātaraṅgī. Pukkasī. Bhamanī. Dramidri
dramidri. Śabarī. Sarālabhe. Hīnamadhama dhātaraṇī. Maholaṇa. Dalavānī
dalavānī. Dalavate. Mahādalīnī. Cālīnī. Muṣṭe cakrapātī. Mahācakrapātī. Śabari
śabarī. Mahāśabarī. Bhūcidginī. Bhūciranginī. Nimi. Nimonggirī. Nīmīndhīnī.
Bhūbhānī svāhā.

Tadyathā. Eṭu ṭu ṭu ṭu. Naṭumirṇī. Kirṇī. Eṃku. Siddhatarī. Calalū. Naṃtu.
Narlamlū. Gallū. Āvatanone. Śekunīrabaradasale. Tarke. Tare. Tarodtu. Nortu.

Tilalalū. Bhūtavatīya. Vatayiye svāhā.

Tadyathā. Aragaṛḍe. Naragaṛḍe. Pāṃsuka. Pāyiye. Kapotakapayiyeye
tabodhanī svāhā.

Whatever monk, son of good family, or daughter of good family, for the sake of protecting all sentient beings, bears, retains, reads, brings to mind, perfectly masters, or extensively and correctly teaches to others this sūtra of the Auspicious Night together with its words and verses and these root mantras of the spirit-soaring secret formulas: fire will be unable to harm that person's body, nor poison, nor weapons, nor water, nor royal punishment, nor the punishment of robbers. Untimely death will not befall them, and they will draw assuredly close to nirvāṇa.

In whatever place one is born,
if one reads this sūtra of the Auspicious Night,
one will assuredly attain recollection of past lives,
attain arhatship, and attain sovereignty.

By a single recitation, throughout all places,
untimely death and the intermediate state are avoided.
One does not bring upon oneself what is untimely and contrary to Dharma.
All sentient beings are protected and purified.

Illness, grief, fear, birth,
bad dreams, confusion, and sorrow —
if spoken of, this Auspicious Sūtra transforms them into splendor.

If it is written out and placed upon the body
of a child at birth, or bound upon a woman's body,
good fortune, radiance,
and that person's splendor will arise.

Whatever non-virtue, however slight,
one has committed through body, speech, or mind —
all of it, through this Auspicious Sūtra,
is protected from untimely death.

Kings, water, fire, lightning,
famine, disease, enemies,
combat and conflict —
if one recalls the Auspicious One, one is protected.

The god's name "Tsandana" renders the Tibetan phonetic transliteration of what in Sanskrit and Pāli is Candana; this is the divine leader identified in the parallel Pāli text as a deity of the Tāvātimsa heaven (the heaven of the thirty-three gods, Skt. Trāyāstrimśa).

The phrase rendered "not running after the past with longing" literally means "not coming into contact afterward with the past," a technical meditative instruction meaning one does not pursue or revisit past experience with craving or conceptual elaboration. Similarly, "remaining ungrasped by present phenomena" means that arising phenomena do not seize or carry away the mind. These renderings reflect the standard commentarial understanding of this triad.

- The phrase rendered "spirit-soaring secret formulas" translates a Tibetan term that literally means "the mantras of those who fly through space" or "the mantras with a basis in sky-travellers," likely referring to a class of protective dhāraṇī associated with ḍākinīs or vidyādhārīs. The rendering is a compromise between literalism and readability for a listening audience.

The mantra strings are transliterated as they appear in the Tibetan phonetic rendering, which is itself a transcription of Sanskrit or a related Indic language. The phonetic reconstructions are approximate; the underlying Sanskrit originals cannot be established with certainty from the Tibetan alone, and the forms appear to name a series of female protective figures including Gaurī, Gāndhārī, Caṇḍālī, Mātṛgī, Pukkasī, and Śabarī, all known classes of ḍākinī-like beings in tantric literature.

The final verse of the passage is syntactically incomplete as given, ending mid-stanza. The translation faithfully renders what is present without supplying a conclusion.

- The mantra syllables in both dhāraṇī passages are transliterated directly from the Tibetan phonetic rendering of Sanskrit; no attempt is made to restore a definitive Sanskrit original, as the phonetic forms show some corruption in transmission. The rendering follows the Tibetan as given.

The term rendered "fault-seeking" translates a Tibetan expression meaning dragging out or exposing another's faults or blemishes, a recognized category of harmful social conduct.

The colophon names are kept in their recognized Sanskrit forms: Jinamitra and Dānaśīla are known translators of the imperial-period translation bureau, and Ye shes sde (Yeshé Dé) is the celebrated Tibetan chief editor of that period.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.